



The Hallerbos

A centuries-old Belgian woodland, where one species of wildflower produces a seasonal transformation

Every spring, the Belgian woodland called the Hallerbos undergoes a spectacular color change. From mid-April to early May, thousands of bluebells burst into bloom, covering its 2 square miles (5 square km) of forest floor in an intense blue-violet. The change is so striking that it has given rise to the woodland's other name: the Blue Forest.



Old and new

Usually, native bluebells grow in old woodland, but most trees in the Hallerbos date from a replanting effort conducted between 1930 and 1950. Its few ancient beeches and oaks are the only ones to survive World War I, when occupying forces devastated what had been a centuries-old forest. The first mention of the Hallerbos dates from 686 CE, and there are references throughout the medieval period; for this reason, official literature considers it "an ancient forest with young trees."

△ DISTINCTIVE DROOP

Bell-shaped flowers of native bluebells produce flowering stalks up to 20 in (50 cm) high, which sag at the top.

▽ TRANSIENT CARPET

Hallerbos bluebells display their most intense color just as beech leaves unfurl. Once the leaves open fully, less light hits the flowers beneath.



▷ TOWERING FOLIAGE

Spruce, including the towering Norway spruce, shares the Bavarian Forest with beech and fir on hillsides, and alder, beech, and willow in valleys.



▽ TRAPPED AIR

Fog is common in the Bavarian Forest and contributes to the area's precipitation. In fall and winter, damp valley floors also produce cold air lakes—areas of trapped frigid, foggy air.

